

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN SYRIA

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Concern for the environment in Syria arrives at a rare and fragile moment — a nation emerging from more than a decade of war into an uncertain transition and the vast task of reconstruction — and it turns above all on water: the **Euphrates**, Syria's great lifeline and breadbasket, throttled to half its historic flow by upstream dams and drought, and the wrecked water and sanitation systems that years of war left in ruins. Syria is a land of river valley and steppe, of ancient farmland and coast, now grappling at once with a transboundary river it does not control, a deepening drought, the environmental wreckage of a long war, and the immense work of rebuilding. That convergence — a lifeline river cut from upstream, a drought-stricken land, a ruined infrastructure, and a reconstruction just begun — is the distinctive ground of environmental effort here, joined to the damaged farmland, the burned forests of the coast, the oil-scarred northeast, and the fragile institutions of a country starting over. For the first time in over a decade, some sanctions have eased and the door to international reconstruction has opened. There is no landmark victory to point to, and the transition is fragile. But the levers, in this rare opening, are real.

In a fragile transition, the tools run through the institutions being rebuilt, the international, the UN, and the reconstruction partnerships now opening, and the communities where safe, protecting people — and, in this rare opening, they are real. The distinctive lever is the **transboundary Euphrates frameworks and diplomacy**: the river is cut upstream and beyond Syria's power to command, so the transboundary water frameworks, and the diplomacy the newly opened moment allows, and the argument for Syria's fair share of a shared river, are the real means to safeguard it. The **water-security argument** is powerful: in a drought-stricken land of scarce and shrinking water, a project that wastes or strains it is self-defeating. The reconstruction now opening is a rare chance to build right: major rebuilding can be held to **environmental assessment and the international reconstruction partners' social and environmental safeguards**, so the rebuilding heals rather than repeats the harm. The **war's environmental legacy** — the oil-scarred northeast, the wreckage — can be documented and pressed toward remediation through the reconstruction and international frameworks. And the **reviving institutions and the international, UN, and community-where-safe channels** offer real avenues this transition affords. These tools are general — the transboundary and water-security arguments, the assessment and safeguards, and the international and reviving-institution channels reach any of the country's harms, with the water the central case. But these tools have grave limits, and this guide states them plainly. The transition is fragile and parts of the country insecure, so the work runs through what functions and with care, protecting everyone. The Euphrates is controlled upstream and beyond Syria's power to command. The drought and the sudden floods strike a dilapidated infrastructure. The war's legacy is vast, and the reconstruction costly and contested. And progress will be slow and partial. So aim for what these tools can genuinely deliver — Syria's fair share of the water pressed through the transboundary diplomacy of this opening; the reconstruction built right through the assessment and the partners' safeguards; the war's legacy documented and remediated — through the reviving institutions and the international, UN, and community channels, seizing the opening with care, and protecting everyone.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

You work, in a fragile transition, through what functions and the opening the moment affords. Press Syria's fair share of the Euphrates through the transboundary frameworks and the diplomacy of this rare opening; wield the water-security argument that straining scarce water is self-defeating; seize the reconstruction to build right, holding it to the environmental assessment and the international partners' safeguards; document and press the war's environmental legacy toward remediation; and work the reviving institutions and the international, UN, and safe-community channels — all with care, constructively, and protecting everyone.

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Syria is a fragile, transitional setting, and honesty about that is the first discipline. The transition is fragile and parts of the country insecure, so the work runs through what functions and with care; the Euphrates is controlled upstream and beyond Syria's command; the drought and floods strike a ruined infrastructure; the war's legacy is vast; and the reconstruction is costly and contested. This is not a fight for open confrontation. It is careful, constructive work through the reviving institutions and the opening's international channels, whose realistic prize is Syria's fair share of the water pressed, the reconstruction built right, and the war's legacy remediated — while everyone is protected and the rare opening is seized with care.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

Who Actually Decides

Authority in a transition is forming and uneven, but the decisions a careful effort can reach run through what functions and the opening: the **water and environment institutions being rebuilt**; the **transboundary Euphrates frameworks** and the diplomacy of the moment; the **international, UN, and reconstruction partners** now engaging; and the **communities where safe**. Keep clear of the insecure areas and the fluid politics, and map which reviving institution or international channel reaches a harm before spending a week on it.

How the Harm and the Rebuilding Move — and Where You Jump In

The harms move differently: the Euphrates is cut upstream; the drought strikes a ruined infrastructure; the reconstruction now begins. You enter through the transboundary frameworks and diplomacy for the water; through the water-security argument for the scarce supply; through the environmental assessment and the partners' safeguards for the reconstruction, so it builds right; and through the documentation and international frameworks for the war's legacy. Enter through what functions and the opening, carefully, and protect everyone.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Follow the water: the Euphrates cut upstream, Syria's fair share, and the transboundary diplomacy the opening allows. Follow the reconstruction: which international partners fund it, and what safeguards they bring. Follow the legacy: the oil-scarred northeast and the war's wreckage to be remediated. Follow the drought: the scarce water a project must not strain. The leverage lies in the transboundary frameworks, the water-security argument, the reconstruction safeguards, and the international channels.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

The watchers here, in a transition, are the reviving water and environment institutions, the transboundary Euphrates frameworks, the international and UN bodies and reconstruction partners with their safeguards, and the communities where safe. A case engages these, through what functions and the opening, seizing

the rare chance to embed protection into the rebuilding.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

No Syrian effort wins swiftly in a fragile transition, and honesty requires saying so. What the careful, constructive tools can deliver is Syria's fair share of the water pressed, the reconstruction built right, and the war's legacy remediated. The single most decisive move is **seizing the reconstruction opening to build right — holding the rebuilding to the environmental assessment and the international partners' safeguards — while pressing the transboundary case for the water**, because the opening is a rare chance to embed protection into a whole country's rebuilding, and because the transboundary diplomacy of the moment is the real means to the water. The reconstruction safeguards and the transboundary frameworks are the distinctive levers; the water-security argument the concrete force; the international and reviving-institution channels the reach. The realistic prize is real, seized carefully.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Ask five questions. **What is the harm?** — the water cut upstream, the drought's strain, a reconstruction project done wrong, the war's legacy. **What reaches it?** — the transboundary frameworks, the water-security argument, the reconstruction safeguards. **What is the opening?** — the transboundary diplomacy and the international partners now engaging. **What must be built right?** — the reconstruction, held to assessment and safeguards. **How is everyone protected?** — the overriding question in a fragile transition. Pick the fight where the transboundary frameworks, the reconstruction safeguards, or the water-security argument gives the clearest, safest handle.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

Build the case in layers, carefully. **Layer one: the harm** — the reduced river flow, the drought's strain, a harmful reconstruction, the war's legacy, documented with the science and the record. **Layer two: the framework and the safeguard** — the transboundary frameworks, the water-security case, the environmental assessment and international safeguards, the remediation the war's legacy needs. **Layer three: the channel and the safety** — which reviving institution, international, or safe community channel to engage, and the discipline of protecting everyone and centring on what is safe and constructive. A case that presses the transboundary water case and holds the reconstruction to its safeguards, in this opening, is one the reviving institutions and the international partners can act on.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Gather the **harm record**: the reduced Euphrates flow, the drought, a harmful project, the war's legacy, the science. Gather the **framework record**: the transboundary water frameworks, the environmental assessment, the international partners' safeguards. Gather the **opening record**: the diplomacy and the reconstruction partnerships now available. Gather the **channel record**: the reviving institutions, the international and UN bodies, the safe communities. The opening makes much of the international record newly available.

STEP 3: BUILDING SUPPORT THROUGH WHAT FUNCTIONS AND THE OPENING

In a fragile transition, the effort centres on what functions and the opening. Build with the **reviving water and environment institutions**; the **international, UN, and reconstruction partners** now engaging, with their safeguards; the **diaspora and technical experts** returning or advising; and the **communities**, where it is safe. Frame everything around safeguarding the water, building the reconstruction right, and remediating the war's legacy — constructively, seizing the opening; protect everyone; and centre on what is safe.

STEP 4: THE TRANSBOUNDARY WATER, THE RECONSTRUCTION SAFEGUARDS & THE LEGACY — SEIZING THE OPENING

Set expectations honestly: the levers are real but constrained by a fragile transition, so the prize is the water pressed, the reconstruction built right, and the legacy remediated — carefully.

The Transboundary Water and the Water-Security Argument

The distinctive lever is the **transboundary Euphrates frameworks and diplomacy** — the river is cut upstream, so the frameworks, the diplomacy of the opening, and the argument for Syria's fair share are the means to safeguard it — joined to the **water-security argument** that straining scarce water is self-defeating. Press the transboundary case and the water-security argument.

The Reconstruction Safeguards

The reconstruction is a rare chance to build right: major rebuilding can be held to **environmental assessment and the international reconstruction partners' social and environmental safeguards**, so it heals rather than repeats the harm. Seize the opening to embed the safeguards.

The War's Legacy and the Channels

The **war's environmental legacy** can be documented and pressed toward remediation through the reconstruction and international frameworks, and the **reviving institutions and the international, UN, and community-where-safe channels** carry the whole effort. Pursued together — the transboundary water and water-security argument, the reconstruction safeguards, and the legacy remediation and channels — these levers seize the opening, while protecting everyone.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Tailor the case, always constructively and carefully. **For the transboundary frameworks**: here is Syria's fair share of a shared river, to be pressed in this opening. **For the reconstruction partners**: here is rebuilding to be held to your environmental and social safeguards. **For the water institutions**: here is scarce water a project must not strain. **For the international and UN bodies**: here is a war's legacy to remediate. **For the communities**: here is the water and land you depend on, to be safeguarded as the country rebuilds. **The golden rule**: press the transboundary water case and the water-security argument, seize the reconstruction to build right through the assessment and safeguards, document and remediate the legacy, and work through what functions — constructively, and protecting everyone.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media must be handled with care in a fragile transition, and largely constructively. Frame any attention around **the water and the chance to rebuild right**: the Euphrates cut from upstream and Syria's fair share, the scarce water, and the rare opening to build a reconstruction that heals rather than harms — never in a

way that endangers anyone or inflames the fluid politics. Carry it through the international and reconstruction press, the reviving institutions, and the diaspora. A few cautions: keep it accurate and constructive; protect everyone; centre on the opening and what is safe; and let the transboundary water case and the reconstruction safeguards carry the weight.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Keep every message careful, constructive, framework- and safeguard-grounded, and protective of everyone.

8A — To a transboundary water framework: press Syria's fair share of the Euphrates in this opening.

8B — On the water-security argument: set out why straining scarce water is self-defeating.

8C — To a reconstruction partner: hold the rebuilding to your environmental and social safeguards.

8D — On the environmental assessment: request the proper assessment of a reconstruction project.

8E — On the war's legacy: document the oil-scarred land or wreckage and press for remediation.

8F — To a reviving water or environment institution: coordinate the safeguarding of the water and land.

8G — To an international or UN body: request engagement in the water, the reconstruction, or the remediation.

8H — To the diaspora and public: tell the story of the water and the chance to rebuild right, protecting everyone.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

The first 48 hours: document the water cut, the drought's strain, or a harmful reconstruction; identify the transboundary frameworks or the partners' safeguards; write the one-page case. **The fastest-moving levers:** the reconstruction safeguards and the transboundary frameworks, in this opening. **Emergency action:** for a harmful reconstruction project, the assessment and the partners' safeguards; for the water, the transboundary diplomacy of the moment. Throughout, work constructively, protect everyone, and centre on what is safe.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

The field here is not merely tilted but fragile and transitional. Recognise it plainly and adjust the aim — not open confrontation, but the water pressed, the reconstruction built right, the legacy remediated. Lean on the levers the moment affords: the transboundary frameworks and diplomacy, the water-security argument, the reconstruction assessment and safeguards, the reviving institutions and international channels. And accept the honest limits — the transition is fragile, the Euphrates controlled upstream, the reconstruction contested — while still seizing the opening carefully, and protecting everyone.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL FRAGILITY — AND WHO IS AT RISK

Here the challenge is not entrenched corruption alone but a fragile, forming state, insecure regions, and fluid politics. Respond through the **careful, constructive, and international channels:** the reviving institutions,

the transboundary frameworks, the reconstruction partners and their safeguards, and the communities where safe. Never in a way that endangers anyone or inflames the politics. **On safety and protection:** this note matters greatly here and governs everything. Syria is a nation in a fragile transition, its state still forming, parts of it insecure, its politics fluid. Work through the reviving water and environment institutions, the international and reconstruction partners, and the communities where it is safe; protect everyone involved; centre on what is safe and constructive; and seize the rare opening with care. Protection is the governing rule.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

The steps run in parallel, carefully and constructively. The documented harm feeds the transboundary case, the reconstruction safeguards, and the legacy remediation at once; the reviving institutions and international partners engage alongside; the diaspora and communities support where safe. A rough timeline: **weeks one to four**, document the harm and the opening's channels; **months two onward**, press the transboundary frameworks, the reconstruction safeguards, and the legacy remediation, and engage the international partners; **through the transition**, seize the opening to safeguard the water and build right. The core discipline: transboundary- and safeguard-grounded, constructive, through what functions, and protective of everyone.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Syria is a fragile, transitional ground, and this guide does not pretend otherwise. It does not claim a swift victory, or that the forming state and insecure regions allow open, easy work, or that a landmark victory exists — none of that is true, and care for everyone is paramount. What it claims is real: that the transboundary Euphrates frameworks and the diplomacy of this rare opening can press Syria's fair share of a shared river; that in a drought-stricken land, a project that strains scarce water is self-defeating; that the reconstruction now opening is a rare chance to build right, held to the environmental assessment and the international partners' safeguards; that the war's environmental legacy can be documented and remediated; and that the reviving institutions and the international, UN, and safe-community channels offer real avenues. These tools are general, reaching any of the country's harms, with the water the central case. The levers work through what functions and the opening, and the prize is Syria's fair share of the water pressed, the reconstruction built right, and the legacy remediated — not a swift stop. For a nation emerging from war into reconstruction, that careful, constructive work — seizing a rare opening through what functions, and protecting everyone — is not a lesser ambition. It is the responsible and hopeful one.